

Eye of the Tiger by Survivor

Identity: Running community

Reason: While running, music is instrumental to help me keep going and bonds me together with other runners in the running community from Track & Field and Cross Country.

For many people, March 17, 2024, was just a normal Sunday. Some individuals went to church, while others were able to sleep in. However, for me, that was the day I ran the Los Angeles Marathon—running from Dodger Stadium to Beverly Hills High School, a staggering 26.2 miles. Weeks before the marathon, I created a playlist of 100+ songs that I planned to listen to while running. Music is not just personal but deeply embedded in running culture. From sharing playlists to the energy it provides during group runs and marathons, music is a universal motivator among runners. Many runners I've trained with preach on the power of using motivational songs such as "Eye of the Tiger", which symbolizes pushing limits and reaching goals. Music often bridges runners to one another—unless you're the 0.1% who refuses to listen to it. Nevertheless, music provides runners, especially me, with the push to continue when our entire bodies want to give up. "Eye of the Tiger" is most memorable to me, as it was the song that started playing during mile 19 of the marathon. The drum and guitar playing was unironically instrumental in helping me continue running. Thoughts of walking or giving up were creeping in, but hearing lyrics such as, "Went the distance, now I'm not gonna stop. Just a man and his will to survive. It's the eye of the tiger, it's the thrill of the fight," was extremely motivational and helped me keep going. If possible, I would quote the entire song to prove the point that music and running are deeply interconnected, especially within the running community. Whether it's listening to music alone with your AirPods or bringing a big speaker while running as a large

group, music and running go hand in hand, making it extremely comforting when faced with a daunting task like completing a marathon. I feel a sense of belonging to the running community, as music helps elevate everyone to reach their full potential and brings runners from different backgrounds together. Furthermore, this song was made extremely famous after its place in *Rocky III* which further highlights both pop culture but also perseverance. In both film and the running community, this song has become a staple in uniting runners to share a common goal of pushing themselves. It is not uncommon for runners to hear this song blasting from speakers at marathons which showcase a shared understanding and connection between runners in the community.

Still D.R.E. by Dr. Dre

Identity: Los Angeles Hip-Pop

Reason: After immigrating to America, my family eventually settled down to the heart of Los Angeles, Central LA which resulted in my familiarity with Angelino culture.

Although one song cannot be representative of the entirety of Los Angeles culture, Dr. Dre is a well-known rapper, and his songs are the most symbolic of West Coast music. One of my favorite lyrics from "Still D.R.E." is, "Still got love for the streets, reppin' 213." A fun icebreaker I enjoy telling people is that my phone number starts with "213," which is the area code for my geographical region of Los Angeles— . This underscores the fact that after I immigrated to Los Angeles, this hip-hop culture that had already been incorporated into my area was my introduction to America. It was the bridge between my Korean childhood and the next chapter of my life. West Coast hip-pop, including "Still D.R.E," is more than just music, it's a cultural statement about resilience, pride, and identity. For many in Los Angeles, especially

immigrants like me, it serves as a powerful bridge between different communities. Regardless of cultural or language limitations between groups, I strongly believe music helps transcend those barriers and, most importantly, helped me become assimilated into Los Angeles. When listening to West Coast music by Dr. Dre and a multitude of artists, I experience an immense amount of nostalgia. Thus, this style of music is more than catchy beats and explicit lyrics; it reminds me of my upbringing, moving to a new place with a different language and culture, which I was fortunate enough to adjust to. I feel a sense of belonging to Los Angeles culture, despite being a foreigner, and I was introduced to a great discography of West Coast music that I otherwise might never have had the opportunity to experience. “Still D.R.E” also resonated with the larger community of Angelenos who see it as a song that represents the city and its deep culture. It references “the streets” and 213 area code to symbolize a collective pride shared by LA natives.

However, I think it is important to mention that I fully understand the implications of Dr. Dre and his questionable past of sexual violence & abuse towards women. As a listener of his, I am extremely disappointed in his history but can also understand his impact in hip-hop. Nevertheless, despite listening to him sometimes, I always have to acknowledge the fact of his wrongdoings.

Way Back then by Jung Jae-il

Identity: Korean Culture

Reason: This song is one of the many examples that is symbolic of Korean Globalization!

As a Korean immigrant who moved to the United States at a young age, I am extremely proud of my culture, especially the elements that Western countries such as the United States have been so open to learning about. When I first moved to America, my culture was not well known, and I felt a bit isolated due to the lack of knowledge others had about Korea in general. However, as time continued and the world became more familiar with Korean culture, elements such as K-pop and Korean dramas became famous worldwide. "Way Back Then" by Jung Jae-il is an instrumental song that was used in the famous Korean television show *Squid Game*, which was released in 2021 and became immensely popular in Western media. I chose this song because I believe it is symbolic of the open-mindedness that Western society has developed towards East Asian culture. This openness has fostered a sense of understanding and appreciation for Korean culture. For example, the global recognition of *Squid Game* allowed many Koreans and non-Koreans to connect over a mutual excitement towards good storytelling and music—in this case through the soundtrack of the television show. Although Western culture has not completely learned all of the facets of Korean culture, I believe that this step towards becoming more open-minded is instrumental in connecting people from different backgrounds and various cultures, especially considering our society is such a massive melting pot of amazing groups. "Way Back Then" represents not only my pride in Korean culture but also the broader community of Koreans who feel a sense of validation and joy in seeing their traditions and stories really seen through the entire world. Ultimately, I feel a sense of belonging to Korean

culture as it not only represents my upbringing but is now becoming shared with others, regardless of whether they have Korean heritage or not.

Discography Citation

Dr. Dre. “Still D.R.E.”. *2001 (Album)*, Aftermath Entertainment. (1999). Accessed via Apple Music, September 9th, 2024.

<https://music.apple.com/us/album/still-d-r-e-feat-snoop-dogg/1440782221>

Jung Jae-il. “Way Back then”. *Squid Game Soundtrack*, Netflix. (2021). Accessed via Apple Music September 9th, 2024.

<https://music.apple.com/us/album/way-back-then/1585115797?i=1585115804>

Survivor. “Eye of the Tiger”. *Eye of the Tiger (Album)*, Primary Wave Music. (1982). Accessed via Apple Music, September 9th, 2024.

<https://music.apple.com/us/album/eye-of-the-tiger/207443884?i=207445080>